

HIGH AND DRY

Even as Ivy League universities across the globe wait for India to open its doors, a deeply divided government dithers, allowing existing unregistered players to continue unregulated

■ **By Satarupa Bhattacharjya**

It's a case of unlikely opponents. Congress President Sonia Gandhi and Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, long considered votaries of reforms in higher education, believe that foreign universities should be allowed to establish their campuses in India. Ironically, the man they thought would usher in liberalisation is firmly in the opposing camp. Instigated by the Left Front, traditionally against foreign investment in all social sectors, a defiant HRD Minister Arjun Singh has openly opposed Commerce Minister Kamal Nath's proposal to allow at least 51 per cent FDI in higher education, embarrassing the prime minister. The standoff between two sections of the

Congress and the Government may not be in the spotlight but thanks to it, the Foreign Educational Institutions (Regulation of Entry and Operations, Maintenance of Quality and Prevention of Commercialisation) Bill, 2007, which was supposed to be tabled in the ongoing monsoon session of Parliament, now stands postponed.

With a Supreme Court stay on the Government move to enhance reservation of OBCs seats in unaided educational institutions, it is a double blow for Singh. The UPA's former banner boy of affirmative action has lost his sheen within the party and the Government. Yet he continues to espouse the Reds' cause. "The minister believes education is too serious a business to be left to foreign and private enterprises," a

bureaucrat in the HRD Ministry says, echoing his minister. The Marxist front organisation—Students Federation of India (SFI)—presented a paper to Singh last month which has five million signatures from 7,464 colleges. SFI members describe the paper as evidence against the move. "There is a more immediate need for legislation that will enable government control over domestic private education providers," Brinda Karat, CPI(M) Politburo member, says.

Having pushed for the entry of foreign educational institutions (FEIs) in India last September, Nath is most displeased with the situation. He had argued that since the country could avail multilateral opportunities under the General Agreement on Trade and Services (GATS) in the World Trade Organisation (WTO), all sectors of the economy should be opened up to FDI. Nath is convinced that universities/colleges in the US and UK view India as an emerging market for higher education. Commerce Ministry officials also believe a queue of Ivy League universities outside India waiting for New Delhi's nod. Following a meeting of education ministers of 25 states in Bangalore in 2005, the HRD Ministry



HEMANT CHAWLA

ARJUN SINGH, HRD MINISTER

Opposes the move. Believes education is too serious a business to be left to foreign and private enterprises. Though his ministry drafted the foreign education providers' bill under duress, he sought help from the Left. Thanks to Left protests, the bill may now not be tabled in the ongoing monsoon session.



RAVI S. SAHANI

KAMAL NATH, COMMERCE MINISTER

Proposed 51 per cent FDI in higher education. His argument that India must link higher education to opportunities under GATS found an instant taker in the PM. The Foreign Educational Institutions (Regulation of Entry and Operations, Maintenance of Quality and Prevention of Commercialisation) Bill, 2007, was born.



PANKAJ NONGIA

BRINDA KARAT, CPI(M) POLITBURO MEMBER

Spoke against liberalisation of higher education at a parliamentary standing committee meeting last month. "Get a bill to enable government control over domestic private education providers instead," she is learnt to have told the members. Congress MP Rahul Gandhi insisted that she change her mind.